

Fate's Edge Quickstart

Your first session in 15 minutes

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Welcome to Fate's Edge

You are exiles, rogues, and survivors in a world where every choice carries weight and every roll of the dice can change the story. This Quickstart contains everything you need to play your first session:

- Core rules (2 pages)
- 4 pre-generated characters
- A complete starter adventure: *The Lantern at Dusk*
- Game Master tips

No other books required.

1 Core Resolution

When your character attempts something risky or uncertain:

1. **Declare** what you want to achieve and how (*Attribute + Skill*).
2. **GM sets Difficulty Value (DV)**: 2 (easy), 3 (standard), 4 (hard), 5+ (extreme).
3. **GM sets Position**: Dominant (safe), Controlled (normal), Desperate (dangerous).
4. **Roll** a number of d10s = Attribute + Skill.
5. **Count successes** (each 6–10 = 1 success). Each 1 gives the GM a **Story Beat (SB)**.
6. **Compare successes to DV** using the table below.

Outcome Matrix

Result	Condition	Effect
Clean Success	successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0	You do it, no complication.
Success with Cost	successes $\geq$ DV, SB $\geq$ 1	You do it, GM spends SB for a twist.
Partial	$0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$	You make progress, gain 1 Boon.
Miss	successes = 0	You fail, gain 2 Boons.

Boons

Boons represent luck and momentum. Hold up to 5. At the end of a scene, reduce to 2 (lost excess). Spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die after seeing the pool.
- Improve your Position by one step before rolling.
- Activate an Asset (see character sheets).
- Convert 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP).

Story Beats (SB) – GM Only

Spend SB to introduce complications:

- 1 SB – minor: noise, dropped item, tick a clock.
- 2 SB – moderate: alarm raised, lose cover.
- 3+ SB – serious: reinforcements, scene shift.

2 Combat in Brief

Same as above, with these additions:

- **Turn order**: Narrative initiative – GM spotlights based on fiction. Ambushers act first.
- **Move**: Shift one range band (Close $\leftrightarrow$ Near $\leftrightarrow$ Far) as a free movement.

- **Action:** Attack, cast a spell, use a talent, etc.
- **Opportunity attack:** Leaving Close range without using *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack.
- **Fatigue:** Each point of Fatigue worsens Position one step (Dominant→Controlled→Desperate). If already Desperate, each Fatigue gives -1 die. Full rest removes all.
- **Harm:** Harm 1 (-1 die), Harm 2 (-2 dice), Harm 3 (incapacitated).

3 Attributes & Skills

Attribute	What it does	Example Skills
Body	strength, agility, endurance	Melee, Athletics, Stealth
Wits	perception, quick thinking	Insight, Lore, Investigation
Spirit	willpower, intuition	Resolve, Arcana, Survival
Presence	charisma, leadership	Sway, Command, Deception

Skill ratings: 0 untrained, 1 novice, 2 competent, 3 expert, 4 master, 5 legendary.

4 Pre-Generated Characters

Choose one. All are balanced for the starter adventure.

1. Kael – Soldier

Once a legionary, now a sellsword.

Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1

Skills: Melee 3, Athletics 2, Endurance 1, Command 1

Talent – Battle Instincts: Once per scene, reroll a failed defense roll.

Asset – Trusted Blade: Your sword never breaks on a Miss.

Bonds: (choose one with another PC) “I saved your life outside Millhaven.”

2. Lyra – Scholar

Expelled from the Academy for forbidden research.

Wits 3, Spirit 3, Body 1, Presence 1

Skills: Lore 2, Arcana 2, Investigation 2, Insight 1

Talent – Lorekeeper: Once per session, recall obscure history without rolling.

Asset – Scholar’s Satchel: Contains books, reagents, a small telescope.

Bonds: “We both lost our place in Silkstrand.”

3. Sera – Shadow

Former guild thief, now a wanderer.

Wits 3, Body 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1

Skills: Stealth 3, Subterfuge 2, Streetwise 1, Melee 1

Talent – Silver Tongue: +1 die to persuade or deceive through speech.

Asset – Shadow’s Cloak: +1 die to stealth rolls in dim light.

Bonds: “You kept my secret when the guards came.”

4. Mira – Healer

Accused of witchcraft for curing the incurable.

Spirit 3, Wits 2, Body 2, Presence 1

Skills: Medicine 3, Survival 2, Insight 2, Nature 1

Talent – Iron Stomach: Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food.

Asset – Healer’s Kit: Bandages, herbs, basic medical supplies.

Bonds: “You trusted me when no one else would.”

Each PC starts with **3 Boons** and **0 Fatigue/Harm**.

5 Starter Adventure – The Lantern at Dusk

Setup

The party is hired by Elder Sarai of the remote village of **Duskwood**. A terrible blight is spreading from the old barrow in the hills – the same barrow where a cursed lantern was buried centuries ago. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle in the valley to break the curse. But the barrow is not empty.

What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.

- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the **Duskwights**).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village's crops in three days.

Clocks

- **Barrow Collapse [6]** – ticks when the party fails a roll inside (GM advances 1 segment per Miss). At 6, the entrance seals – escape becomes a Desperate group action.
- **Lena's Agenda [4]** – ticks at the end of each scene inside the barrow. When it fills, Lena has already taken the lantern; the party must chase her.

Scene 1 – The Entry

The barrow entrance is a narrow stone passage. A faint green glow pulses from deeper inside. **Obstacle:** A cave-in blocks the way (Body+Athletics to climb, DV 3, Controlled). *Partial:* You get through but disturb rubble – tick Barrow Collapse +1. *Miss:* You are pinned by a rock – mark Harm 1 and tick Collapse +1.

Scene 2 – The Spirit Corridor

The passage widens into a hall where three Duskwights drift. They do not attack unless provoked, but they will not let anyone pass without an offering. **Offer a memory or a secret** (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Clean Success:* They bow and let you pass. *Partial:* They take your offering but also steal a random piece of equipment (GM chooses). *Miss:* They attack as a single mob (Cap 2, Harm 1 each, 2 Fatigue each on hit). Combat follows normal rules.

Scene 3 – The Lantern Chamber

The lantern sits on a stone altar. Quick Lena is there, trying to pry it loose. **Confront Lena:** She is not a fighter. Offer a deal or intimidate her (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Success:* She leaves peacefully, but warns that “others will come for it.” *Partial:* She agrees to split any reward but demands a favor later (start a Debt Clock [4]). *Miss:* She triggers a trap – a stone door starts closing (tick Collapse +2).

Scene 4 – Escape

After you take the lantern, the barrow begins to collapse in earnest. **Group skill challenge:** The party needs 3 successes before 2 failures to escape. Each PC describes how they help (e.g., Athletics to brace a door, Lore to read ancient escape runes). DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Collapse +1. If Collapse reaches 6 before you escape, the entrance seals – you must find another way (start a second Clock [4] to dig out, each success removes 1 segment; on failure, mark Fatigue). *Success:* You burst into the moonlight, lantern in hand. *Failure:* You escape, but someone is left behind – captured or lost. The remaining party must rescue them later.

Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Breaking the curse requires a simple ritual (Spirit+Lore, DV 2). *Success:* The blight lifts. Elder Sarai rewards each PC with a **String** – “The village owes you.” *Partial:* The curse lifts, but the lantern cannot be destroyed – it will attract another danger soon. *Miss:* The curse is only pushed back one year. A dark spirit escapes and will become a recurring enemy.

Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end. XP can be spent:

- Raise an Attribute: new rating × 3 XP (downtime = new rating days)
- Raise a Skill: new level × 2 XP (downtime = new level days)
- Learn a Minor Talent (2–4 XP) – examples: *Keen Senses*, *Second Wind*, *Combat Reflexes*
- Acquire a Minor Asset (4 XP) – safehouse, contact, or special tool.

Rush rule: Skip downtime by accepting a *Haste clock [4]*. If it fills before you finish, the new ability has a flaw (GM's choice).

6 GM Tips – Running Your First Game

- **Start strong:** Use the cold open – “The barrow's green light flickers. You smell rot. What do you do?”
- **Set DV to 3** by default. Only raise to 4 or 5 if the task is truly legendary.

- **Spend SB early and often.** A single SB can turn a quiet scene into a tense one.
- **Fail forward:** On a Miss, never say “nothing happens.” Always introduce a new complication or advance a clock.
- **Use the pre-gens** – they are designed to showcase different play styles.
- **Keep the spotlight moving.** Ask quiet players directly: “Sera, what are you doing while this happens?”
- **End on a cliffhanger.** When the lantern is lifted, describe the ceiling cracking – then say “to be continued.”

Optional – Magic in One Page

If a player wants a magical character, use these simplified rules (based on the *Free Caster* path).

Spellcasting

Choose a magical **Element** (Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death). Describe your spell using **TAGS**. Each tag increases DV by 1. Dangerous tags (Teleport, Transform, Dominate) increase DV by +2 instead. **DV = 1 + number of tags** (max 6). Roll **Spirit + Arcana**.

Example: “*I throw a [Burning] [Area] blast*” = DV 3.

Backlash

If you roll a Miss or the GM spends SB, magic backfires:

- 1–2 SB: minor flare, Fatigue 1, eerie sound.
- 3+ SB: Harm 1, the spell affects an ally, or a Patron omen appears.

Sample Spells (DV 2–4)

- *Light* [Illuminate] – DV 2. Create a small, sustained light.
- *Mend* [Mend] – DV 2. Heal 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally.
- *Shield of Air* [Ward] [Defend] – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- *Flame Cloak* [Burning] [Area] – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

For full magic systems (Runekeepers, Invokers, Cantors), see the complete *Fate’s Edge Player’s Guide*.

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Ready for More?

This Quickstart gives you a complete first session. For the full experience:

- **Player’s Guide:** Attributes, Skills, Talents, magic systems, character advancement, and the world.
- **GM Guide:** Clocks, fronts, advanced Story Beat management, faction rules, and high-tier play.
- **Adventures:** *Blood and Silk* (village defense), *Beyond Millhaven* (mediation), *The Brass Gate* (heist).

All available under CC-BY from the author. Now gather your dice and step into the Edge.